Mothers were all the same, and she was sure to get upset.

He felt good listening to her. It didn't matter what she was talking about, he just wanted to hear the voice that was so dear to him.

'Do you know why people settle down on the Moon so easily?' she was philosophizing. 'It's because they are in the gravitation field of their native Earth, under their native Sun. It's the space allotted to us by nature. But if you leave your Sun…anything might happen…'

He listened and listened as if drinking water from a spring on the Earth, in the shade of trees. His mother, looking in the direction of the vast blue globe, lowered her voice and continued:

'Look, son, isn't it a miracle? The Earth floats through space, all by itself.



See the snow-cap on the pole, and the glittering ocean! The cradle of life. And you want to leave this fabulous beauty!'

He suddenly saw everything with different eyes. He saw how beautiful his native planet was, a real wonder of nature.

He had never felt that way before. His heart ached.

'When will you take your holidays?'

'I don't know, Mother… That's why I asked you to come. I don't know when we'll see each other again'.

But he knew very well that there would be no holidays and that his mother was seeing him for the last time. The thought of such a tremendous journey was already sending a chill through his heart.

'At least try to come in the Autumn,' she pleaded, 'in time for the apples and pears… and the water-melons.'

'You think I don't want to walk barefoot on the dewy grass?'

'Of course, you'll walk on the dewy grass. And you could visit your relatives and friends'.

She shrank from the thought that her son might go off into space and be lost to his relatives forever.

'They've deepened our pond; it's full of fish now, You like fishing…'

'Operator on duty, …… report to office,' a voice bellowed from the loud-speaker.

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